

ROHIT JAIN PARAS

THE TEMPEST (From second left) State unit chief Poonia, BJP president Nadda and Raje

RAJASTHAN/ BJP

AN OPPOSITION IN DISARRAY

By Rohit Parihar

On January 2, the Rajasthan BJP unit held one of its continuing Jan Aakrosh rallies in Jodhpur against the "misgovernance" of the Ashok Gehlot-led Congress government, but much like the response in many other parts of the state, the turnout was poor. This despite the presence of Union ministers Gajendra Singh Shekhawat and Gen. (retd) V.K. Singh. Matters, it seems, had not improved since December 1 when BJP national president J.P. Nadda was confronted with a similar situation at the launch of the Jan Aakrosh Yatra.

The state BJP's woes have continued with the bypoll loss in Sardarshahar assembly seat in Churu, with the party losing by nearly 27,000 votes. With this, the BJP has lost six of the last seven bypolls held in the state (including two seats it held). It sent a clear message—Gehlot's Congress may be facing all-round derision in the state and beyond for its endless factionalism, but the BJP is even more in disarray ahead of the assembly election due in December 2023.

The BJP brass is possibly aware of the ground reality, hence the two-week, statewide Jan Aakrosh Yatra with local BJP leaders travelling in 52 vehicles to interact with the masses.

Former CM Vasundhara Raje, still the tallest BJP leader in the state, had been mostly sidelined in this effort, except during the launch rally. The drubbing in Sardarshahar came as a dampener for the anti-Raje lobby—it was hoping for a popular endorsement of the central BJP's line of ignoring her heft in the state. The loss in Himachal the same day—which Prime Minister Narendra Modi attributed to a "1 per cent margin"—lifted no spirits either. As everyone recalled gloomily, the BJP had lost 2018 in Rajasthan by a similar margin. Other party insiders are also pointing to why regional satraps are essential to fight polls in states such as Rajasthan where the Congress has a strong organisational base, and wafer-thin swings can make or mar fortunes.

GOING WITH RAJE AS CM CANDIDATE MAY BE THE ONLY VIABLE OPTION FOR THE BJP, GOING BY ITS RECENT DISAPPOINTMENTS

State BJP chief Satish Poonia, organisational general secretary Chandrashekhar and deputy leader of the opposition Rajendra Rathore were given a free hand but have so far failed to deliver. Rathore has been the main strategist in most of the bypolls while Poonia, a Jat, has failed to lasso in even his caste cohort. He claims the Jan Aakrosh rallies have so far collected 1.4 million complaints and touched base with 20 times the number of people. But ground reports suggest most of these interactions ended inconclusively. The leaders have tried to use issues like